personal, or collective), the filters through which it receives information, and the degree to which it believes in explanations that seem to us "unreasonable." There is no doubt that this is a very interesting measurement tool, and one in which the Americans have invested a great deal of thought and experience. However, it does not claim to be scientific, nor is it based on any scientific methodology. And when one is dealing with issues of survival, it takes a lot of courage to make decisions only on the basis of this profiling tool. I believe that an intelligence officer, from the IDF or the Mossad, relying only on an intelligence assessment based on an analysis of the enemy and precluded from assessing Israel's own capabilities with regard to the Iranian nuclear issue (as this is done by the political leader and the body that works under him or her, such as the National Security Council), will be forced to present the decision maker with an intelligence assessment that is based on a very pessimistic scenario.

The instinct of survival triumphs over every other instinct. But does it stand up to the Iranian ideological and theological test that sanctifies death if it achieves the ultimate goal of restoring the global Islamic caliphate? To further complicate this dilemma, one can point to two cases in which the Iranians preferred reason over the ideological imperative. The first time was in 1988, when Supreme Leader Khomeini, who saw that Iran was being defeated by Iraq, made a unilateral decision to end the war. In explaining his decision, he wrote that for him it was like "drinking a cup of poison." The second instance was in 2004, following the US invasion of Iraq; the Iranians, fearing they were next, unilaterally decided to suspend their military nuclear program temporarily. Here, too, logic prevailed over religious considerations. This example is weak, however, in view of the fact that what the Iranians reacted to was a huge military move and the American invasion of Iraq, rather than a verbal threat.

Below are some other dilemmas related to the decision on courses of action against a nuclear Iran:

- Experience has taught that a defensive approach alone in reaction to provocation (for example, the launching of missiles on the southern city of Sderot) is not only ineffective but also liable to exact a prohibitive price.
- A carrot will be perceived by the other side as a weakness if it has not been preceded by a stick or a credible demonstration of power.